came as a complete surprise, especially because he was requested to demonstrate openness at the meeting. “They notified us that the presentation should be complete, including data on the status of the division and its organization, the number of missile launchers and missiles brought in, and plans for dismantling the missiles and taking them back to the Soviet Union,” recalled Anatoly Gribkov, one of the planners of Operation Anadyr, who was then the representative of the General Staff in Cuba. Statsenko followed Pliev’s order and made as complete a report as possible.[24]

As the Americans later learned, Statsenko told U Thant that the dismantling of the missiles was underway and would be finished soon. “We started the dismantling on Sunday at 5:00 p.m.,” Statsenko told U Thant. “It will be all over by tomorrow night, or at the latest on Friday [November 2], when we will have finished the bulldozing of the sites.… We have asked for ships. We don’t know when they will be in the ports. But the equipment will be in the ports Thursday night or Friday morning. We are crating the equipment at the ports for the sea voyage. Most of it will not have to be crated because of deck loading. The bases no longer exist. Even the pads will be gone, but no Cuban observation of the dismantling is permitted.”[25]

Statsenko was telling the truth. Upon his return to the Soviet Union a few months later, he filed a report providing essentially the same information on the dismantling of the missiles that he had given U Thant. He reported to his commanders that the whole task of dismantling the sites was accomplished in less than three days. “At 1500 hours on October 28, 1962, the Commander of the Group of Soviet Forces in Cuba gave me directive No. 7665, dated October 28th, 1962, in which the USSR Minister of Defense, on the basis of a decision of the Soviet government, ordered the dismantling of the launching sites and the relocation of the division to the Soviet Union in full,” wrote Statsenko. “In the period from October 29th through October 31st, 1962, division units completed the dismantling of the launch sites in full.”

General Gribkov recalled that what he had witnessed during those days was not “dismantling” but “the breaking down of the positional structures that had taken so much of the soldiers’ labor to build.” Statsenko was clearly unhappy. He complained to Gribkov: “It was you who pressed me